What if Israel ruled Jordan? Sources

Reel by @noamroz__, October 2026. All GDP figures are World Bank World Development Indicators, read via FRED (St. Louis Fed).

GDP per person, current US$

	1965	Latest
Israel	$1,688	$60,337 (2025)
Jordan	$546	$5,348 (2025)
Lebanon		$4,473 (2024)
Egypt		$3,086 (2025)
Syria		$847 (2023, latest available)

- Israel: fred.stlouisfed.org/data/PCAGDPILA646NWDB
- Jordan: fred.stlouisfed.org/series/PCAGDPJOA646NWDB (series starts 1965; annual values = GDP / population, MKTGDPJOA646NWDB and POPTOTJOA647NWDB)
- Lebanon: fred.stlouisfed.org/series/PCAGDPLBA646NWDB
- Egypt: fred.stlouisfed.org/series/PCAGDPEGA646NWDB
- Syria: fred.stlouisfed.org/series/PCAGDPSYA646NWDB

The "what if" line is imagination, not data. It takes Jordan's real 1965 value and grows it at Israel's rate. No forecast.

Building in the desert

- Modern drip irrigation: Netafim, Kibbutz Hatzerim, 1965 (Wikipedia, "Netafim"; "Simcha Blass")
- 86% of Israel's drinkable water desalinated, 2022 (Wikipedia, "Water supply and sanitation in Israel")
- Arava desert farms: more than 60% of Israel's fresh vegetable exports (Israel MFA, "Coaxing crops from the sand")
- R&D: Israel 6.35% of GDP (2023), highest in the world; Jordan 0.70% (2016, latest). World Bank / UNESCO UIS, via Wikipedia "List of sovereign states by research and development spending"

Jordan's own progress

- Life expectancy at birth: Jordan 52.7 (1960) to 78.0 (2024); Israel 83.2 (2024). World Bank SP.DYN.LE00.IN via FRED

My view

- Growth comes from freedom and institutions, not from a ruler. See Acemoglu, Johnson and Robinson, Nobel economics prize 2024 (nobelprize.org)
- Security zone: Hezbollah fire on northern Israel from 8 Oct 2023; Israel's Cabinet Secretary on buffer zones in Lebanon and Syria (JNS, 27 Mar 2025)
- Extra: in Oct 2021 Israel agreed to sell Jordan 50 million m³ of water a year (Ynet, 12 Oct 2021)

Map: Natural Earth (public domain).